

A Preliminary Phonemic Analysis of Haryanvi

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Abstract

This paper presents a preliminary phonemic analysis of Haryanvi (ISO 639-3: bgc), an Indo-Aryan language spoken primarily in the Indian state of Haryana. The study focuses on the West-Central variety of Haryanvi spoken in parts of Bhiwani district and the Hansi region of Hisar district. The analysis is based on lexical data collected from native speakers and supplemented with lexical sources available online. Minimal pair analysis is used to identify phonemic contrasts. The analysis identifies an inventory of thirty-two consonant phonemes, nine vowel phonemes, and three diphthongs. The study also examines syllable structure and the phonotactic distribution of segments. The findings contribute to the phonological description of Haryanvi, which remains relatively under-documented in linguistic literature.

Keywords: *Haryanvi, Phonology, Phonemic Inventory, Indo-Aryan Languages*

1. Introduction

Haryanvi (ISO 639-3: bgc) is an Indo-Aryan language spoken primarily in the northern Indian state of Haryana and in adjoining regions of Delhi, Rajasthan, and western Uttar Pradesh. It is generally classified within the Western Hindi subgroup of the Indo-Aryan language family and shares several linguistic features with related varieties such as Khariboli and Braj Bhasha (Singh, 1970; Ethnologue, 2021). Despite its widespread use in everyday communication across the region, Haryanvi has received relatively limited attention in descriptive linguistic research, particularly in the area of phonology.

The number of speakers of Haryanvi is difficult to determine precisely because Indian census data typically subsume Haryanvi and related varieties under the broader category of Hindi. Nevertheless, Ethnologue reports several million speakers of Haryanvi and closely related varieties (Ethnologue, 2021). The language is primarily written in the Devanagari script, although its written use is relatively limited compared to its widespread use in spoken communication. Haryanvi is also spoken by communities outside India, including populations that migrated to Pakistan during the partition of the Indian subcontinent in 1947 (Madan, 1995).

Haryanvi comprises several regional varieties that exhibit phonological and lexical variation across different districts of Haryana. Among the commonly recognized varieties are Bangru (also referred to as Jattu), Deswali, Khadar, and Bagri, which are spoken in different parts of the state and neighboring regions (Singh, 1970; Meena & Rao, 2014). The present study focuses on the West-Central variety of Haryanvi spoken in parts of Bhiwani district and in the Hansi region of Hisar district. This variety occupies a central geographical position within Haryana and shares features with the Bangru variety described in earlier linguistic studies (Singh, 1970) and with Deswali spoken in central Haryana.

Previous research on Haryanvi has largely focused on grammatical description, particularly morphology and syntax, while comparatively less attention has been given to its phonological system. Earlier descriptive work on related varieties such as Bangru provides valuable insights into the grammatical structure of the language (Singh, 1959, 1970). However, detailed analyses of the phoneme inventory, phonetic realization, and phonotactic patterns of Haryanvi remain relatively scarce.

The present study aims to provide a preliminary phonemic analysis of the West-Central variety of Haryanvi based on minimal pair evidence and phonetic observation. The study identifies the vowel and consonant phonemes of the language and examines their phonetic realization and distribution. In addition, the paper discusses basic syllable structures and phonotactic patterns observed in the data. By documenting the phoneme inventory and phonological characteristics of this variety of Haryanvi, the study seeks to contribute to the descriptive understanding of a language that remains relatively underrepresented in linguistic research.

2. Data and Methodology

The data analyzed in this study represent the West-Central variety of Haryanvi spoken in parts of Bhiwani district and in the Hansi region of Hisar district in the Indian state of Haryana (See Image 1). This variety occupies a central position within the Haryanvi-speaking region and shares several linguistic features with the Bangru variety described in earlier grammatical studies (Singh, 1970). Like other varieties of Haryanvi, it belongs to the Western Hindi subgroup of the Indo-Aryan language family (Ethnologue, 2021).

West-Central Haryanvi Variety

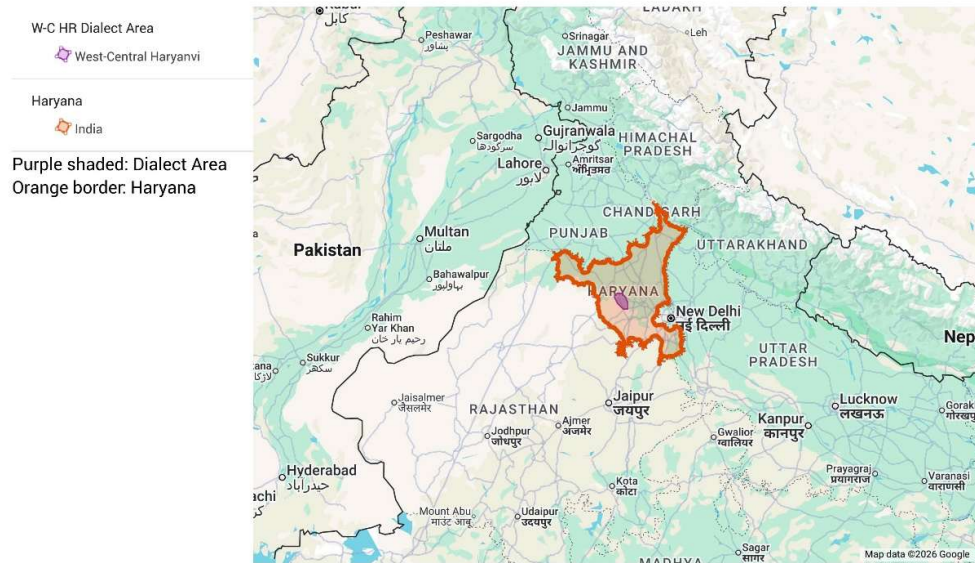


Image 1.

The primary dataset for this study was collected from native speaker knowledge utilizing CIIL wordlist. The author, being a native speaker of this variety of Haryanvi, served as the primary language consultant. The lexical items and pronunciations used in the analysis were further verified through consultation with two additional native speakers from the same linguistic region. These consultations were conducted informally to confirm pronunciation and lexical meanings.

The dataset consists mainly of lexical items used to identify phonemic contrasts through minimal pair analysis. Additional lexical material was also consulted from available glossaries of Haryanvi in order to cross-check forms and meanings (Jatland Glossary, n.d.). The phonological analysis presented in this study is therefore based on a combination of native speaker intuition, elicited lexical data, and supporting lexical sources.

Minimal pair analysis was used as the primary method for identifying phonemic contrasts in the language. Words exhibiting minimal phonetic differences but contrasting meanings were examined to establish the phonemic status of vowels and consonants. In addition to minimal pairs, the phonetic realization and distribution of segments were also considered in determining the phonological inventory of the language.

Since this study represents a preliminary investigation of the phonological system of Haryanvi, the analysis is based on a limited dataset. Further research involving a larger number of speakers and dialectal varieties would help refine the phonemic inventory and provide a more comprehensive account of the phonology of Haryanvi.

3. Phoneme Identification Using Minimal Pairs

Phonemes in a language can be identified through the analysis of minimal pairs, which are pairs of words that differ in only one sound segment but have different meanings. The existence of such contrasts provides evidence that the differing sounds function as separate phonemes in the language. Minimal pair analysis is a widely used method in phonological studies for determining the phonemic inventory of a language (Ladefoged & Johnson, 2015).

In the present study, minimal pairs were used to identify both vowel and consonant phonemes in Haryanvi. Words that differed in a single segment while maintaining the same phonetic environment were examined in order to establish phonemic contrasts. In addition to minimal pairs, near-minimal pairs and distributional evidence were also considered in cases where perfectly matched minimal pairs were not available. The following sections present minimal pair evidence for vowel and consonant contrasts in the West-Central variety of Haryanvi examined in this study.

3.1 Vowels

The vowel system of the West-Central variety of Haryanvi examined in this study consists of nine vowel phonemes and three diphthongs. The vowel inventory includes five short vowels /ə, a, i, u, e/ and four long vowels /i:, u:, ε:, o:/. In addition to these monophthongs, three diphthongs /əo:, ai:, eu:/ are attested in the dataset. The approximate phonetic positions of these vowel phonemes are illustrated in Fig 1.

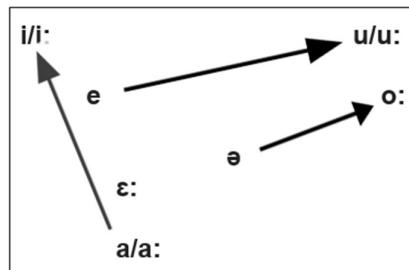


Fig. 1

The phonemic status of these vowels is established primarily through minimal pair analysis. Words that differ in only one vowel segment but have distinct meanings provide evidence that the contrasting vowels function as separate phonemes in the language. The following subsections present minimal pair evidence for the vowel phonemes identified in the West-Central variety of Haryanvi.

3.1.1 Minimal pair evidence for vowel contrasts in Haryanvi is presented below.

a. /ə/ vs /a:/

g^həta: 'big dark clouds'

g^ha:ta: 'Loss'

b. /a:/ vs /i/

da:na: 'granule'

da:ni 'donator'

na:na: 'mother's father'

na:ni 'mother's mother'

c. /u/ vs /u:/

puri: 'A city in the Indian state of Odisha'

pu:ri: 'full (adjective)'

suŋ 'hear'

su:ŋ 'moment'

d. /o:/ vs /əo:/

mo:ɽ 'Turn'

məo:ɽ 'The artificial, shining crown worn by the bridegroom during the marriage ceremony'

e. /i:/ vs /u:/

ɽa:i: 'Feminine of Tau/ Father's elder brother's wife is called Tai /an elderly, respectable lady'

ɽa:u: 'Father's elder brother'

f. /e/ vs /a/

ek 'One'

ak 'the name of a plant which releases white liquid'

g. /a:/ vs /ai:/

na: 'No'

nai: 'Barber'

la: 'bring'

lai: 'bring' (feminine)

- h. /ə/ Vs /ɛ:/
aɖə 'take cover'
aɖɛ: 'here'

3.1.2 Phonetic Realisation of Vowels

In addition to establishing phonemic contrasts through minimal pairs, it is also important to examine the phonetic realization and distribution of vowel phonemes in the language. The phonetic realization of a phoneme refers to the way in which it is pronounced in actual speech, which may sometimes vary depending on its phonological environment. In the present study, the phonetic properties of the vowel phonemes of Haryanvi are described in terms of vowel height, backness, and rounding, following standard phonetic classifications (Ladefoged & Johnson, 2015).

The following subsections describe the phonetic realization and distribution of each vowel phoneme in the West-Central variety of Haryanvi. Examples are provided to illustrate the occurrence of these vowels in different positions within a word.

3.1.2.1 Short Vowels

a. /ə/

The phoneme /ə/ is a short, central, unrounded vowel typically realized as [ə]. In the data examined for this study, /ə/ occurs primarily in word-initial and medial positions. It rarely occurs in word-final position. Examples illustrating the occurrence of /ə/ are given below.

- (1) ənta: [ənta:] 'marble balls'
(2) bəhmi: [bəhmi:] 'superstitious person'

b. /a/

The phoneme /a/ is a short, open, central vowel realized as [a]. It occurs in both word-initial and medial positions. In certain phonetic environments, particularly in open syllables, it may be realized with slightly greater duration, though this does not necessarily represent a phonemic contrast in all cases. Examples are provided below.

- (3) a[a: [a[a:] 'a low level shelving unit'
(4) rə[na: [rə[na:] 'to mix up'

c. /i/

The phoneme /i/ is a short, close, front, unrounded vowel realized as [i]. In the data examined, this vowel occurs primarily in word-initial and medial positions. It is less commonly attested in word-final position in the dataset used for this study. Examples include the following.

- (5) ina:m [ina:m] 'prize'
(6) iṭ [iṭ] 'here'

d. /e/

The phoneme /e/ is a short, mid-close, front, unrounded vowel realized as [e]. Unlike some other short vowels, /e/ may occur in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions. Examples illustrating its distribution are given below.

(7) ed̪i: [ed̪i:] ‘heel’

(8) li:k̪ɛ [li:k̪ɛ] ‘small parts of tree branches or grass’

e. /u/

The phoneme /u/ is a short, close, back, rounded vowel realized as [u]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions in the data analyzed. Examples include the following.

(9) ub^ha:ŋa: [ub^ha:ŋa:] ‘barefooted’

(10) luk [luk] ‘hidden’

3.1.2.2 Long Vowels

a. /i:/

The phoneme /i:/ is a long, close, front, unrounded vowel realized as [i:]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions. Examples illustrating its distribution are given below.

(11) i:n̪ [i:n̪] ‘brick’

(12) ɖi:va: [ɖi:va:] ‘lamp’

(13) tʃ^hori: [tʃ^hori:] ‘young girl’

b. /u:/

The phoneme /u:/ is a long, close, back, rounded vowel realized as [u:]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

(14) u:k̪u: [u:k̪u:] ‘a squatting sitting posture’

(15) t̪u:m [t̪u:m] ‘heavy silver anklets’

c. /ɛ:/

The phoneme /ɛ:/ is a long, open-mid, front, unrounded vowel realized as [ɛ:]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and final positions.

(16) ɛ:nd̪i: [ɛ:nd̪i:] ‘easygoing’

(17) bərgɛ: [bərgɛ:] ‘similar to’

d. /o:/

The phoneme /o:/ is a long, mid-close, back, rounded vowel realized as [o:]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

(18) o:t̪ŋa: [o:t̪ŋa:] ‘to tolerate or bear a burden’

(19) mo:ɖɖa: [mo:ɖɖa:] ‘a wandering monk’

3.1.2.3 Diphthongs

In addition to monophthongs, three diphthongs are attested in the dataset examined for this study.

a. /əo:/

The diphthong /əo:/ occurs primarily in word-initial and medial positions.

(20) əo:sɪna: [əo:sɪna:] ‘to mix flour with water’

(21) b^hrəo:ʈa: [b^hrəo:ʈa:] ‘bundle of harvested crops’

b. /ai:/

The diphthong /ai:/ occurs in both word-initial and word-final positions.

(22) ai: [ai:] ‘come (feminine)’

(23) ɖuk^hai: [ɖuk^hai:] ‘to cause pain’

c. /eu:/

The diphthong /eu:/ occurs primarily in word-final position.

(24) bəʈeu: [bəʈeu:] ‘daughter’s husband’

(25) beu: [beu:] ‘impure, untouchable’

3.2 Consonants

The consonant system of the West-Central variety of Haryanvi explored in this study consists of thirty-two consonant phonemes. These consonants can be classified according to their place and manner of articulation, as well as voicing and aspiration. The consonant inventory includes plosives, nasals, affricates, fricatives, approximants, and lateral consonants. As in many Indo-Aryan languages, the stop system shows a contrast based on both voicing and aspiration.

The phonemic status of these consonants is verified primarily through minimal pair analysis. Words differing in only one consonant segment but having different meanings provide evidence that the contrasting segments are separate phonemes in the language. The following sections present minimal pair evidence and phonetic descriptions of the consonant phonemes identified in the West-Central variety of Haryanvi.

3.2.1 Plosives

Plosive consonants in Haryanvi are produced with a complete closure in the vocal tract followed by a release of air. The plosive system of Haryanvi exhibits contrasts based on voicing, aspiration, and place of articulation. In the West-Central variety of Haryanvi examined in this study, plosives occur at four primary places of articulation: bilabial, dental, retroflex, and velar. The phonetic realization and distribution of each plosive phoneme are described below.

a. /p/

The phoneme /p/ is a voiceless, unaspirated, bilabial plosive [p]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

- (26) panna: [panna:] ‘a traditional block of a village’
- (27) li:pŋa: [li:pŋa:] ‘to apply soil mixed with dung’
- (28) k^ha:p [k^ha:p] ‘group of village councils’

b. /b/

The phoneme /b/ is a voiced, unaspirated, bilabial plosive [b]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

- (29) baŋgəd [baŋgəd] ‘a rough, thick stick’
- (30) tʃəo:bara: [tʃəo:bara:] ‘a room on the upper floor’
- (31) dʒra:b [dʒra:b] ‘socks’

c. /t/

The phoneme /t/ is a voiceless, unaspirated, dental plosive [t̪]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

- (32) ʈabər [ʈabər] ‘child or children’
- (33) sulʈa: [sulʈa:] ‘right side’
- (34) ro:t̪ [ro:t̪] ‘a thick handmade bread’

d. /d/

The phoneme /d/ is a voiced, unaspirated, dental plosive [d̪]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

- (35) da:fəd [da:fəd] ‘a scar caused by an insect sting’
- (36) bəŋd̪ [bəŋd̪] ‘closed’
- (37) kəd̪ [kəd̪] ‘when’

e. /ʈ/

The phoneme /ʈ/ is a voiceless, unaspirated, retroflex plosive [ʈ]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

- (38) ʈu:m [ʈu:m] ‘heavy silver anklets’
- (39) rəhpət̪ [rəhpət̪] ‘slap’
- (40) feʈŋa: [feʈŋa:] ‘to meet someone’

f. /ɖ/

The phoneme /ɖ/ is a voiced, unaspirated, retroflex plosive [ɖ]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

- (41) ɖa:ŋgər [ɖa:ŋgər] ‘livestock’
- (42) ɖo:lɖa: [ɖo:lɖa:] ‘a thick cotton carpet’
- (43) ha:ɖ [ha:ɖ] ‘bone’

g. /k/

The phoneme /k/ is a voiceless, unaspirated, velar plosive [k]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

- (44) kəd [kəd] ‘back’
- (45) ki|ki: [ki|ki:] ‘to yell’
- (46) b^hɾək [b^hɾək] ‘restlessness or tension’

h. /g/

The phoneme /g/ is a voiced, unaspirated, velar plosive [g]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

- (47) ga:dh [ga:dh] ‘sediment in stagnant water’
 (48) d̥o:ga: [d̥o:ga:] ‘a wooden walking stick’
 (49) fa:g [fa:g] ‘festival of colours (Holi)’

3.2.2 Aspirated Plosives

In addition to the unaspirated plosives described above, Haryanvi also exhibits a series of aspirated plosives. Aspiration involves the release of a burst of air following the stop closure and constitutes a phonemic contrast in many Indo-Aryan languages. In the West-Central variety of Haryanvi examined in this study, aspiration contrasts with the corresponding unaspirated plosives at several places of articulation. These aspirated consonants may occur in word-initial, medial, and, in some cases, word-final positions.

a. /p^h/

The phoneme /p^h/ is a voiceless, aspirated, bilabial plosive [p^h]. It occurs primarily in word-initial and medial positions.

- (50) p^ha:l [p^ha:l] ‘plough blade’
 (51) p^ho:d [p^ho:d] ‘boil or swelling’

b. /b^h/

The phoneme /b^h/ is a voiced, aspirated, bilabial plosive [b^h]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

- (52) b^ha:t̪t̪a: [b^ha:t̪t̪a:] ‘stone’
 (53) əlb^hed̪a: [əlb^hed̪a:] ‘twist of a rope’
 (54) d̥o:b^h [d̥o:b^h] ‘a deep marshy pond’

c. /t̪^h/

The phoneme /t̪^h/ is a voiceless, aspirated, dental plosive [t̪^h]. It occurs in word-initial and medial positions.

- (55) t̪^ha:l [t̪^ha:l] ‘a large metal plate’
 (56) t̪^ho:k [t̪^ho:k] ‘in large quantity’

d. /d̪^h/

The phoneme /d̪^h/ is a voiced, aspirated, dental plosive [d̪^h]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and occasionally word-final positions.

- (57) d̪^ho:r̪e: [d̪^ho:r̪e:] ‘near or adjacent’
 (58) b̪ənd̪^ha: [b̪ənd̪^ha:] ‘blockage’

e. /t̪ʰ/

The phoneme /t̪ʰ/ is a voiceless, aspirated, retroflex plosive [t̪ʰ]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

- (59) t̪ʰa:dd̪a: [t̪ʰa:dd̪a:] ‘a strong, well-built person’
 (60) ko:t̪ʰi: [ko:t̪ʰi:] ‘a large house’

f. /dʰ/

The phoneme /dʰ/ is a voiced, aspirated, retroflex plosive [dʰ]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

(61) dʰəbbi: [dʰəbbi:] ‘friend’

(62) dʰedʰ [dʰedʰ] ‘a foolish person’

g. /kʰ/

The phoneme /kʰ/ is a voiceless, aspirated, velar plosive [kʰ]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

(63) kʰa:p [kʰa:p] ‘a group of village councils’

(64) bukʰa:ri [bukʰa:ri] ‘a grain storage area in a house’

h. /gʰ/

The phoneme /gʰ/ is a voiced, aspirated, velar plosive [gʰ]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

(65) gʰəŋa: [gʰəŋa:] ‘more’

(66) biɡʰən [biɡʰən] ‘problem or quarrel’

(67) u:ngʰ [u:ngʰ] ‘boredom’

3.2.3 Nasals

Nasal consonants are produced with the lowering of the velum, allowing air to pass through the nasal cavity while the oral cavity is partially or completely closed. In the West-Central variety of Haryanvi examined in this study, three nasal phonemes are attested: /m/, /n/, and /ŋ/. These nasals contrast with each other primarily in terms of place of articulation and occur in different positions within a word. The phonetic realization and distribution of these nasal phonemes are described below.

a. /m/

The phoneme /m/ is a voiced, bilabial nasal [m]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

(68) ma:ʃŋa: [ma:ʃŋa:] ‘to show off’

(69) kʰa:mkʰa: [kʰa:mkʰa:] ‘without reason’

(70) ga:m [ga:m] ‘village’

b. /n/

The phoneme /n/ is a voiced, dental (or alveolar) nasal [n]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

(71) na:ʃŋa: [na:ʃŋa:] ‘to deny’

(72) bi:ja:ba:n [bi:ja:ba:n] ‘a remote place where people do not live’

(73) tʃuskŋa: [tʃuskŋa:] ‘to respond by moving physically’

c. /ŋ/

The phoneme /ŋ/ is a voiced, retroflex nasal [ŋ]. In the dataset examined, this phoneme occurs primarily in medial and word-final positions and rarely appears in word-initial position.

(74) ɖa:mən [ɖa:mən] ‘a heavy skirt traditionally worn by village women’

(75) ɖiŋŋa: [ɖiŋŋa:] ‘to move slightly from one place’

3.2.4 Rhotics

Rhotics in Haryanvi include two phonemes that differ primarily in place and manner of articulation: the alveolar trill /r/ and the retroflex flap /ɽ/. These sounds are distinguished phonemically and contrast in certain lexical items. The phonetic realization and distribution of these rhotic consonants are described below.

a. /r/

The phoneme /r/ is typically realized as a voiced alveolar trill [r]. In the West-Central variety of Haryanvi examined in this study, /r/ occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

(76) ro:lɑ: [ro:lɑ:] ‘loud noise produced by a crowd’

(77) tɑ:bər [tɑ:bər] ‘children’

(78) t̪əreɽ [t̪əreɽ] ‘crevice’

b. /ɽ/

The phoneme /ɽ/ is a voiced retroflex flap [ɽ]. In the dataset examined, this phoneme occurs primarily in medial and word-final positions.

(79) t̪o:ɽ [t̪o:ɽ] ‘result or outcome’

(80) t̪ʰepɽi: [t̪ʰepɽi:] ‘dung cake’

3.2.5 Affricates

Affricates are consonants that are produced with a complete closure in the vocal tract followed by a gradual release into a fricative segment. In the West-Central variety of Haryanvi examined in this study, four affricate phonemes are attested: /tʃ/, /tʃʰ/, /dʒ/, and /dʒʰ/. These affricates occur primarily at the palato-alveolar place of articulation and contrast in terms of voicing and aspiration.

a. /tʃ/

The phoneme /tʃ/ is a voiceless, unaspirated, palato-alveolar affricate [tʃ]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

(81) tʃɑ:m [tʃɑ:m] ‘lather’

(82) tʃɑ:ɳʃək [tʃɑ:ɳʃək] ‘suddenly’

(83) gəʃʃ [gəʃʃ] ‘astonishing’

b. /tʃʰ/

The phoneme /tʃʰ/ is a voiceless, aspirated, palato-alveolar affricate [tʃʰ]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

(84) tʃʰɑ:tʰ [tʃʰɑ:tʰ] ‘roof’

(85) tʃʰeʃʰər [tʃʰeʃʰər] ‘mischief or troublesome behavior’

(86) pu:tʃʰ [pu:tʃʰ] ‘respect’

c. /dʒ/

The phoneme /dʒ/ is a voiced, unaspirated, palato-alveolar affricate [dʒ]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

(87) dʒəɳu: [dʒəɳu:] ‘such as’

(88) gəɖʒbəɳ [gəɖʒbəɳ] ‘a charming woman’

(89) bʰɑ:dʒ [bʰɑ:dʒ] ‘run’

d. /dʒʰ/

The phoneme /dʒʰ/ is a voiced, aspirated, palato-alveolar affricate [dʒʰ]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

(90) dʒʰo:k [dʒʰo:k] ‘leaning to one side’

(91) mo:ŋi:dʒʰa:ra: [mo:ŋi:dʒʰa:ra:] ‘a childhood disease’

(92) ro:ndʒʰ [ro:ndʒʰ] ‘a wild animal resembling a horse and deer’

3.2.6 Fricatives

Fricatives are consonants produced by forcing air through a narrow constriction in the vocal tract, resulting in audible friction. In the West-Central variety of Haryanvi examined in this study, several fricative phonemes are attested at different places of articulation. These include labiodental, dental, alveolar, postalveolar, velar, and glottal fricatives. The fricative /f/ occurs mainly in loanwords and may alternate with [pʰ] in native pronunciation.

a. /f/

The phoneme /f/ is a voiceless, labiodental fricative [f]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

(93) fərvət [fərvət, pʰərvət] ‘skilled or experienced person’

(94) dʒəmfər [dʒəmfər, dʒəmpʰər] ‘women’s shirt’

(95) bəraf [bəraf, bərapʰ] ‘ice’

b. /v/

The phoneme /v/ is a voiced, labiodental fricative [v]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

(96) bʰa:v [bʰa:v] ‘price’

(97) va:r [va:r] ‘day or occasion’

(98) ʈa:v[a:] [ʈa:v[a:]] ‘hasty’

c. /s/

The phoneme /s/ is a voiceless, alveolar fricative [s]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

(99) sa:nkəl [sa:nkəl] ‘door latch’

(100) ʈo:sa: [ʈo:sa:] ‘thumb used teasingly’

(101) ʈi:s [ʈi:s] ‘thirst’

d. /ʃ/

The phoneme /ʃ/ is a voiceless, postalveolar fricative [ʃ]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

(102) ʃo:ʈi: [ʃo:ʈi:] ‘seasonal river’

(103) ʃa:ʃni: [ʃa:ʃni:] ‘sugar syrup’

(104) fəja:ʃ [fəja:ʃ] ‘dandruff’

e. /h/

The phoneme /h/ is a voiceless glottal fricative [h]. It occurs in word-initial and very rarely in medial positions. However, no instances of word-final position /h/ were found in the dataset. Even in loan words word-final /h/ gets replaced by some vowel.

(105) ha:ŋ [ha:ŋ] ‘after some time’

(106) dʒo:həŋ [dʒo:həŋ] ‘village pond’

3.2.7 Approximants

Approximants are consonants produced with a relatively open configuration of the vocal tract in which the articulators approach each other but do not create the level of constriction required for fricative turbulence. In the West-Central variety of Haryanvi examined in this study, one approximant phoneme /j/ is attested.

a. /j/

The phoneme /j/ is a voiced palatal approximant [j]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

(107) ja:ɽɛ: [ja:ɽɛ:] ‘here’

(108) həɽja:ŋa: [həɽja:ŋa:] ‘Haryana’

(109) ko:j [ko:j] ‘someone’

3.2.8 Laterals

Lateral consonants are produced by allowing air to pass along one or both sides of the tongue while the central part of the tongue makes contact with the roof of the mouth. In the West-Central variety of Haryanvi examined in this study, two lateral phonemes are attested: the alveolar lateral approximant /l/ and the retroflex lateral /ɭ/. These two consonants contrast in terms of place of articulation.

a. /l/

The phoneme /l/ is a voiced alveolar lateral approximant [l]. It occurs in word-initial, medial, and word-final positions.

(110) la:mŋi: [la:mŋi:] ‘harvesting crops with a sickle’

(111) mɛ:lkʰo:ra: [mɛ:lkʰo:ra:] ‘earthen scrubber’

(112) so:həl [so:həl, so:əl] ‘a measuring instrument used during wall construction’

b. /ɭ/

The phoneme /ɭ/ is a voiced retroflex lateral approximant [ɭ]. In the dataset examined, this phoneme occurs primarily in medial and word-final positions.

(113) so:ɭa: [so:ɭa:] ‘right side’

(114) ra:ɭ [ra:ɭ] ‘saliva’

The consonant system of the West-Central variety of Haryanvi includes thirty-two phonemes distributed across several places and manners of articulation. These consonants exhibit contrasts in voicing and aspiration, which are characteristic features of many Indo-Aryan languages. The phonemes described in the preceding sections can be organized according to their articulatory properties. The consonant inventory of Haryanvi is presented in Fig. 2, which summarizes the distribution of consonants.

Manner of Articulation	Place of Articulation								
	<i>Bilabial</i>	<i>Labiodental</i>	<i>Dental</i>	<i>Alveolar</i>	<i>Postalveolar</i>	<i>Retroflex</i>	<i>Palatal</i>	<i>Velar</i>	<i>Glottal</i>
<i>Plosive</i>	p b		t̪ d̪			ʈ ɖ		k g	
<i>Aspirated Plosive</i>	p ^h b ^h		t̪ ^h d̪ ^h			t̪ ^h d̪ ^h		k ^h g ^h	
<i>Nasal</i>	m		n			ɳ			
<i>Trill</i>			r						
<i>Tap or flap</i>						ɽ			
<i>Fricative</i>		(f) v		s	ʃ				h
<i>Affricates</i>					tʃ ^h dʒ ^h tʃ dʒ				
<i>Approximant</i>							j		
<i>Lateral approximant</i>				l		ɭ			

Fig. 2 presents the consonant inventory of Haryanvi organized according to place and manner of articulation.

Where consonants occur in pairs, the symbol to the right represents the voiced counterpart of the segment.

4. Syllable Structure

The syllable is an important unit of phonological organization in many languages and typically consists of three main components: the onset, nucleus, and coda. The onset is usually occupied by one or more consonants at the beginning of the syllable, the nucleus forms the central element of the syllable and is most commonly realized as a vowel, and the coda consists of consonants that occur at the end of the syllable. Together, the nucleus and the coda form the rhyme of the syllable.

In the West-Central variety of Haryanvi examined in this study, syllables may consist of one or more consonants followed by a vowel, with an optional consonant occurring in the coda position. The nucleus of the syllable is always occupied by a vowel. Based on the data analyzed, several common syllable patterns can be observed in Haryanvi.

4.1 Syllable Constituents

A syllable in Haryanvi may contain the following components:

- Onset (C): one consonant occurring at the beginning of the syllable
- Nucleus (V): a vowel forming the core of the syllable
- Coda (C): a consonant occurring at the end of the syllable

Thus, the general syllable template for Haryanvi may be represented as:

$$(C)(C) V (C)$$

4.2 Syllable Types

The following syllable structures are attested in the dataset analyzed in this study.

TABLE 1. SYLLABLE STRUCTURES IN HARYANVI

Structure	Example	Gloss
V	a:	‘come’
CV	na:	‘no’
CVC	ɖa:k	‘jump’
CCV	prə	‘prefix-like cluster in borrowed forms’
CVC.CCV	ɖ ^h ə̃m.ɖ ^h ma:	‘a loose or weak structure’

These examples illustrate that syllables in Haryanvi may occur as simple vowel syllables or may include consonants in both onset and coda positions. In some cases, consonant clusters may occur at the beginning of a syllable, particularly in borrowed forms or in certain morphological environments.

4.3 Syllable Distribution

In most cases, the nucleus of a syllable is occupied by a vowel phoneme, while consonants may appear in onset or coda positions. Retroflex consonants such as /ɭ/, /ɻ/, and /ɳ/ tend to occur more frequently in medial or coda positions rather than in word-initial position. This distribution reflects a phonotactic tendency observed in the dataset examined for this study.

5. Phonotactic Distribution of Syllable Constituents

Phonotactics refers to the permissible combinations and distributions of phonemes within syllables in a language. In Haryanvi, consonants and vowels occur in different syllable positions such as the onset, nucleus, and coda. The nucleus of the syllable is always occupied by a vowel, while consonants may appear in onset or coda positions.

Based on the dataset examined in this study, most consonant phonemes in Haryanvi may occur in onset position, while a somewhat smaller set of consonants appears in coda position. Vowel phonemes function as syllable nuclei and do not occur in onset or coda positions.

5.1 Onset Position (C₁)

The following consonants may occur in syllable-initial (onset) position:

p, b, b^h, t, ɖ, t^h, ɖ^h, t̪, ɖ̪, t̪^h, ɖ̪^h, k, g, g^h, m, n, r, p^h, f, v, s, ʃ, dʒ, tʃ^h, dʒ^h, tʃ, h, j, l

These consonants are commonly attested at the beginning of syllables in the dataset.

5.2 Nucleus Position (V)

The nucleus of a syllable in Haryanvi is occupied by vowel phonemes. The following vowels occur as syllable nuclei:

ə, a, i, u, e, i:, u:, ε:, o:

In addition, the following diphthongs may also function as syllable nuclei:

əo:, ai:, eu:

5.3 Coda Position (C₂)

The following consonants are attested in syllable-final (coda) position:

p, b, b^h, t, d, d^h, d^ʱ, t, d, t^h, d^ʱ, k, k^h, g, g^h, m, n, ŋ, r, ɽ, f, v, s, ʃ, dʒ, tʃ^h, dʒ^h, tʃ, h, j, l, ɭ

5.4 Observations

The phonotactic patterns observed in the dataset suggest that most consonants may occur in both onset and coda positions. However, certain retroflex consonants such as /ɳ/, /ɽ/, and /ɭ/ appear more frequently in medial or coda positions and are rarely attested in word-initial position. This tendency reflects a phonotactic pattern commonly observed in many Indo-Aryan languages.

6. Conclusion

This paper has presented a preliminary phonemic analysis of the West-Central variety of Haryanvi spoken in parts of Bhiwani district and the Hansi region of Hisar district in Haryana. Based on minimal pair evidence and phonetic observation, the study identifies a phonemic inventory consisting of thirty-two consonant phonemes, nine vowel phonemes, and three diphthongs. The findings provide a descriptive account of the segmental phonology of this variety of Haryanvi.

The analysis shows that the consonant system of Haryanvi exhibits several features typical of Indo-Aryan languages, including contrasts based on voicing and aspiration in plosive consonants as well as the presence of retroflex consonants. The vowel system consists of both short and long vowel contrasts along with a small set of diphthongs. The study also examined the phonetic realization and positional distribution of vowel and consonant phonemes within words.

In addition to the segmental inventory, the study explored the basic syllable structure and phonotactic patterns of the language. The analysis indicates that syllables in Haryanvi typically follow patterns such as V, CV, CVC, and CCV. The nucleus of the syllable is always occupied by a vowel, while consonants may occur in onset or coda positions. The phonotactic distribution observed in the data suggests that most consonants can occur in both onset and coda positions, although certain retroflex consonants such as /ɳ/, /ɽ/, and /ɭ/ appear more frequently in medial and coda positions.

As this study represents a preliminary phonological description based on a limited dataset, further research is needed to provide a more comprehensive account of the phonology of Haryanvi. Future studies may examine a larger set of lexical data, include a greater number of speakers, and investigate phonological processes and dialectal variation across different varieties of Haryanvi. Such

research would contribute to a deeper understanding of the phonological system of this language and support the broader documentation of Indo-Aryan linguistic diversity.

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